

policies and achieve its goals. Whether it be general or specialized management—

such as personnel, purchasing, production or sales—the key to all business management lies in the words: *directing human activities*.

No one possessing the attitudes of the disgruntled executive I met at the cocktail party could possibly *direct* human beings in any activity. His type can only drive or bully those unfortunate enough to work under him. It is hardly necessary to point out that these are not methods to which employees will respond favorably or by which they can be prevailed upon to work productively.

But our horrible example's managerial failings do not end there. His straight-faced avowal that he doesn't question his orders and always carries them out "to the letter, regardless of the consequences," brands him a toady.

It also proves him to be an extremely stupid person who has no concept of the responsibilities every executive owes to his superiors and the company for which he works.

True, an executive should conscientiously and loyally carry out the instructions he receives from those above him.

But this does not mean he should carry them out blindly,

61

like some mindless automation. If he is a good executive, it follows that he will give careful consideration to "the consequences."

However exalted his position, no man is infallible. Even board chairmen are human, and thus liable to make mistakes. An alert junior executive who recognizes errors, fallacies or weaknesses in the orders he receives from his superiors and fails to call their attention to them is not being conscientious or loyal. He is simply shirking his responsibility.